

Small Nations but Great Differences: Political Orientations and Cultures of the Crimean Tatars and the Gagauz

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THIS ARTICLE EXAMINES THE DIFFERING POLITICAL ORIENTATIONS of the Crimean Tatars and the Gagauz, two Turkic minorities in Ukraine and Moldova. Crimean Tatars in Ukraine expressed anti-communist and anti-Russian political preferences, while Gagauz in Moldova showed strong support for pro-communist and pro-Russian parties and politicians. This study analyses the role of cultural factors in the political attitudes and behaviour of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz and uses data from surveys, elections and referendums. The analysis shows that the distinct historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in the Ottoman Empire, the Russian Empire, the Soviet Union and Romania led to the emergence of distinct political cultures among these ethnic groups and affected their political behaviour and attitudes in post-communist Ukraine and Moldova.

Research question

The Crimean Tatars and the Gagauz, Turkic minorities in Ukraine and Moldova, are similar in many aspects. The populations of these ethnic groups are concentrated in a small number of regions of Ukraine and Moldova. Almost all Crimean Tatars in Ukraine live in Crimea. The absolute majority of the Gagauz live in the Gagauz Yeri region in Moldova and the Odessa region in Ukraine. These ethnic groups are small minorities in Ukraine and Moldova. The Crimean Tatar population of Ukraine numbers about 250,000 or 0.5% of the total population. The 2001 census recorded that about 10% of the population in Crimea were Crimean Tatars, compared with 2% in 1989. Russians are the majority of the population (60%) in Crimea, and Ukrainians are the second largest minority in the autonomous region (24%).¹ The significant increase in the Crimean Tatar population in Crimea is a result of their return migration from Central Asian republics, where they were exiled by Stalin at the end of World War II. The Gagauz population in Moldova and Ukraine numbers more than 180,000. There are about 150,000 Gagauz in Moldova, or approximately 4% of the total population.²

The Crimean Tatars and the Gagauz live primarily in rural areas. Both Crimean Tatars and Gagauz are Turkic ethnic groups, and their languages are Turkic. Both

ethnic groups lived under the rule of the Ottoman Empire until about two centuries ago, when they came under the rule of the Russian Empire. Finally, political movements advocating national autonomy have found strong support among elites and masses of these ethnic minorities since the end of the 1980s.

Despite these similarities, Crimean Tatars and Gagauz have displayed very different political orientations since the collapse of Soviet communism. Crimean Tatars in Ukraine expressed anti-Russian and anti-communist political preferences. In contrast, Gagauz in Moldova expressed strong support for pro-communist and pro-Russian parties and politicians. These differences have persisted for almost two decades. The question is why these two Turkic ethnic groups have such different political orientations.

Most studies explain distinctive political behaviour and attitudes of ethnic minorities, including Crimean Tatars and Gagauz, by ethnic and economic differences and self-interest of politicians.³ Studies which emphasise the role of political culture in regional political divisions in the former Yugoslavia and the Soviet Union, including the Crimea region in Ukraine, often attribute ethnic cleavages to 'ancient hatred' that resulted from ancient conflicts and persisted to the present time. Nomadic ancestors of Crimean Tatars and Mongols, then referred to as Mongol-Tatars, fought and killed a large proportion of the ancestors of the modern Ukrainians and Russians in Kyiv Rus at the beginning of the last millennium. However, an 'ancient hatred' cannot explain the pro-Russian values of the Gagauz and the absence of a conflict between the Gagauz and Ukrainians. Even before the ancestors of Crimean Tatars arrived along with Mongol armies, nomadic ancestors of the Gagauz, e.g. the Pechenegs, were engaged in violent conflicts with Kyiv Rus for a long time.

This article analyses the role of cultural factors in political attitudes and behaviour of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in post-communist Ukraine and Moldova. The study links distinct historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in the Ottoman Empire, the Russian Empire, the Soviet Union and Romania to the emergence of distinct political cultures among these Turkic ethnic groups, and consequently, their different political orientations in the post-communist era.

Theoretical framework

Historical experience, also referred to as historical legacy or memory, represents a major source of political culture. Political culture refers to values and norms that are shared by individuals. Almond & Verba define the political culture of a nation as 'the particular distribution of patterns of orientation toward political objects among the members of the nation'.⁴ This means that not every individual in a particular group shares the dominant culture of that group.

The concept of political culture implies that certain key values and norms persist over a long period of time, in contrast to political attitudes, which are much more volatile. While support for a particular political party or idea often significantly changes from one election or survey to another election or survey in a few years, as a result of shifts in political attitudes that are caused by such factors as economic situation and charismatic appeal of political leaders, political culture refers to fundamental political orientation that changes much more slowly. For example, significant popular support for the New

Deal policies and parties and a sharp rise in the union membership rate in the United States in the 1930s and the 1940s reflected changes in attitudes caused by the Great Depression and World War II. Because fundamental political values of Americans remained individualist and laissez-faire, however, support for the New Deal policies and parties and the union membership rate in the US dropped soon after the economic situation improved and World War II ended.⁵

Therefore, it is important to analyse election results, surveys and other data concerning political orientation over a significant period of time to separate political culture patterns from temporary changes in political attitudes. Thick description, e.g. historical and ethnographical studies, is a traditional way to research culture.⁶ Historical studies provide data on the formation and evolution of political cultures. However, historians tend to focus on a single country or region and avoid theoretical generalisations. This is the case with most of the historical studies of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz.

Shared historical experiences bring the values and norms of individuals close to one another, while different histories have the opposite effect. Socialisation in family, school, church, a circle of friends and other social institutions serves as a mechanism that transmits these values and norms from one generation to the next. As a result, different historical legacies shape the political culture of ethnic, linguistic, regional and racial groups.⁷

For example, differing historical legacies have affected the institutional performance of Italian regional governments.⁸ Similarly, differences in colonial institutions in North America and Latin America resulted in significant divergences in the development of these societies in post-colonial times. The legacy of British rule in the United States and Canada was more favourable for the emergence and evolution of a decentralised government than the legacy of Spanish and Portuguese rule in Latin America.⁹ In post-communist countries of the former Soviet Union and Eastern Europe, a divergence in growth, economic liberalisation and corruption is linked to different historical experiences of their populations in the Russian Empire, the Ottoman Empire, the Austro-Hungarian Monarchy and the German Empire.¹⁰ However, most of these studies do not provide detailed analyses of mechanisms that helped to transfer such historical experiences to modern times.

In historical perspective, political culture can be viewed as analogous to a geological structure, which includes layers or deposits accumulated over a long time.¹¹ Critical junctures in history, such as the unification or break-up of a country and defeat or victory in war, provide a major impetus for the formation of political culture. Using an analogy proposed by Max Weber, the critical juncture represents a point in the evolution of political culture where a dice becomes 'loaded'. In the course of the subsequent historical development the loaded dice directs the evolution of culture in a particular direction.¹² This implies that not all historical legacies are equally important. A period when political culture starts to form and massive political upheavals, e.g. protracted and repeated wars, mass expulsions etc., affect the majority of the population, is more crucial in the evolution of political culture than other historical periods and events.

Religious legacies also influence the evolution of culture. Modern civilisations and regional conflicts are often associated with religions, e.g. Western Christianity,

Orthodox Christianity, Islam, Buddhism and Confucianism. This theory of political culture regards conflicts in the former Yugoslavia, the former Soviet Union and many developing countries as the clash of civilisations.¹³

Because religious identities can be culturally transmitted even to the illiterate population, they often precede the formation of national identities.¹⁴ When the majority of the population was illiterate, their religious, local and status-based identities were dominant. Different experiences of religious groups had a major effect in formation of their political values. Such historical differences were transmitted from one generation to another by means of socialisation in families, schools and religious communities. Therefore, historical religious differences continue to affect political orientation in modern times, even though a large proportion of the population is no longer deeply religious.

This study argues that historical experiences transmitted from one generation to another through socialisation in family, community, education system and media played the crucial role in the emergence and evolution of distinct political cultures among Crimean Tatars and Gagauz. Institutions of Islam and slavery in the Ottoman Empire and the experience of Crimean Tatars during their exile in the Soviet Union at the end of World War II were crucial factors in the formation of anti-Russian and anti-communist political values among Crimean Tatars. In contrast, discrimination and persecution of Gagauz because of their adherence to Orthodox Christianity in the Ottoman Empire, their mass migration to the Bessarabia region in the Russian Empire, as well as historical experiences in Romania and the Soviet Union, fostered a pro-Russian and pro-communist orientation among this Turkic people.

Data and methodology

This study uses survey data and results of elections and referendums, and it compares political behaviour and attitudes of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in Ukraine and Moldova. Surveys that are employed include the following: the 1990 Academy of Sciences of Moldova survey, the 1995 World Values Survey in Moldova, the 1998 Laitin/Hough survey in Moldova, the 1996 USIA/SOCIS-Gallup survey in Crimea, the 2001 Ukrainian Centre for Economic and Political Studies survey in Crimea and a 1995 survey of the Gagauz in the Odessa region of Ukraine. The article also examines data from Soviet, national and regional elections and referendums held in Crimea and the Gagauz region since 1990.

The study uses a comparative analysis of the historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz that were shaped by different political and religious institutions and policies in the Ottoman Empire, the Russian Empire, the Soviet Union and Romania. The article also outlines a general mechanism of intergenerational transmission of historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz. In contrast to Crimean Tatars, research on Gagauz history is very limited—in the West, Moldova, Ukraine, Russia and other countries. For example, there are no English-language books on Gagauz politics and history, while English-language books on Crimean Tatars number in dozens.¹⁵ Even the basic facts about the Gagauz are not always known. For instance, one study identifies the Gagauz in Moldova as a Muslim minority.¹⁶ Another study attributes the presence of the Gagauz in Moldova to

Ottoman rule in this region, while, in fact, almost the entire Gagauz population migrated from Bulgarian and Romanian parts of the Ottoman Empire to the Bessarabian region of the Russian Empire because of their persecution as Orthodox Christians.¹⁷

Support for political parties and political leaders

Crimean Tatars established and overwhelmingly supported their own ethnically based political organisations in elections in the Crimean autonomous region. For example, the Medzhlis won all 14 of the seats reserved for the Tatars in the 1994 election to the Crimean parliament. A 2001 poll, conducted by the Ukrainian Centre for Economic and Political Studies in Crimea, showed that 11% of the respondents supported the Medzhlis. Since the percentage of Crimean Tatars in the population of Crimea is of similar magnitude, this poll result indicates that the absolute majority of Crimean Tatars supported the Medzhlis. The Medzhlis and other Crimean Tatar organisations consistently opposed Russian separatism in Crimea.

The Medzhlis and pro-Ukrainian parties and politicians, whose main base of popular support was in Western Ukraine, often supported each other in order to counter the pro-Russian movement in Crimea. Mustafa Dzhemilev, the chairman of the Medzhlis, was elected to the Ukrainian parliament on the Rukh list in the 1998 election.¹⁸ Such cooperation allowed Rukh, the nationalist Ukrainian movement, to gain about 7% of the votes in Crimea and rank third among political parties in the region. Crimean Tatar voters gave Rukh about two-thirds of their votes in the region. Similarly, in the 2002 parliamentary election, the Nasha Ukraina bloc won 10% of the votes in Crimea with support from Crimean Tatars.

Similarly, the Medzhlis and other major organisations of Crimean Tatars backed Viktor Yushchenko, the leader of Nasha Ukraina, in all rounds of the 2004 presidential election in Ukraine.¹⁹ The Crimean Tatars contributed a significant proportion of the 14% of the votes Yushchenko received in the repeat second round of the presidential election in Crimea. In contrast, Viktor Yanukovych, the pro-Russian presidential candidate, obtained 83% of the votes in Crimea.²⁰

However, this cooperation between the Medzhlis and nationalist/pro-Ukrainian organisations was a marriage of convenience that resulted from mutual anti-communist and anti-Russian orientation. Some Crimean Tatar organisations, which were much less influential than the Medzhlis, advocated separation from Ukraine. For example, the Union of Crimean Turks (Azat Kyyrim) declared establishment of an independent state of Crimean Tatars its main goal. In 1999 the Crimean Tatar National Movement initiated collection of signatures calling for an international tribunal to investigate genocide and ethnocide against Crimean Tatars. The statement named Ukraine as the main defendant because it controlled the territory belonging to the Crimean Tatar people.²¹

Support for pro-Russian and pro-communist political leaders and organisations, which advocated the separation of Crimea from Ukraine, was low among Crimean Tatars. This political orientation differentiated Crimean Tatars not only from the majority of ethnic Russians but also from a significant proportion of ethnic Ukrainians, who supported pro-Russian and pro-communist parties and politicians

in Crimea. For example, the Russia bloc received 67% of the votes in the 1994 parliamentary election. This organisation favoured two possible options for Crimea: creation of an independent Crimean Republic, or the region's reunification with Russia. The Crimean Tatar Medzhlis opposed pro-Russian candidates and supported a pro-Ukrainian candidate during the 1994 presidential election in Crimea. Yuri Meshkov, the candidate of the Russia bloc, won in the second round with 73% of the votes.²² After the disintegration of the Russia bloc in the mid-1990s the Communist Party of Crimea, affiliated with the Communist Party of Ukraine, became the leading political force in the region. The Communist parties received more than one-third of the votes in the 1998 parliamentary election in the Crimean Republic and in the national elections in Ukraine in 1998 and 2002.

In contrast to Crimean Tatars, the Gagauz expressed strong support for pro-communist and pro-Russian parties and politicians. Gheorghe Tabunshchik, the former First Secretary of the Moldovan Communist Party in the Gagauz region, was elected governor of the Gagauz autonomous region in 1995. In October 2002 he ran as a Moldovan Communist Party candidate and won the governor election in Gagauz Yeri for a second time. Tabunshchik received 51% of the vote in the second round of the election in the autonomous region.

A 1990 poll showed that support for a pro-Soviet/anti-independence movement in Moldova and a Gagauz separatist movement was strongest in the Gagauz region (24% and 25% respectively). Support for the Popular Front, a nationalist Moldovan movement, was much weaker in the Gagauz region (21%) than in other parts of the historical Bessarabian region of Moldova with the notable exception of Bendery (Tighina), a city that would become part of the Transdnistrian Republic (19%). The Popular Front was supported by 42% of the respondents in Chisinau and 32% of the respondents in other districts of Bessarabian Moldova.²³

According to the 1995 World Values Survey in Moldova, 15% of respondents in the Gagauz region expressed the desire to vote for Communists. Support for various nationalist/pro-Moldova parties was lowest in the Gagauz region (0%), compared with 29% in the capital and 34% in the rest of Moldova. The absolute majority of the respondents in the region (85%) favoured centrist parties. However, the apparent support for the centrist Moldovan parties did not manifest itself during the elections held the same year. For example, the Agrarian Democratic Party, which was supported by 55% of the respondents in the region in the 1995 World Values Survey, received 12% of the votes in the 1995 Gagauz regional assembly election.²⁴

In the 1995 parliamentary election the Communist Party of Moldova received 14%, while Vatan, a Gagauz party headed by Stefan Topal, received 15% of the votes in the region. The Gagauz People's Party, which opposed Gagauz secessionism, won only 4% of the votes. The Agrarian Democratic Party, which received 47% of the votes in the 1995 local elections in Moldova, obtained just 12% of the vote in the Gagauz region. Non-party candidates received more than half of the votes (55%).²⁵

Three-quarters (74%) of the voters in the Gagauz autonomous region voted for the Party of Moldovan Communists along with two smaller pro-communist parties in the 1998 parliamentary election. These parties gathered only 31% of the votes in other regions of Moldova, excluding Transdnistria. A similar pattern was repeated in the 1999 local elections when 53% of the voters in the Gagauz region supported the

Communist parties, compared with 33% received by the Communist parties in the rest of Moldova, excluding Transdnistria. Similarly, in the 2001 parliamentary election the Party of Moldovan Communists won 81% of the vote in Gagauz Yeri compared with 49% in the rest of Bessarabia.²⁶

The results of the parliamentary election in Moldova in March 2005 provided fresh evidence of the pro-Russian and pro-communist political values of the Gagauz. The Patria-Rodina bloc received the majority of the votes in the Gagauz autonomous region (51%), while it scored only 5% of the national vote in Moldova. The Socialist Party and a splinter Party of Socialists established this electoral bloc. These parties, which were once allied with the Party of Moldovan Communists, offered a pro-Russian electoral programme that included Moldova's integration in the Common Economic Space and a union of ex-Soviet republics led by Russia and support of a Russian plan for resolution of the Transdnistrian conflict. The Ravnopravie movement, which also favoured a union with Russia, received the support of more than 5% of the Gagauz voters compared with less than 3% in Moldova overall.²⁷

In spite of the administrative resources used by the ruling Party of Moldovan Communists, support for this party in Gagauzia in the 2005 parliamentary election dropped by more than half compared with the 2001 parliamentary election. Vladimir Voronin, the leader of this party and president of Moldova, did not accept the Russian plan for Transdnistria and changed his orientation from the Commonwealth of Independent States towards European integration in order to stay in power. The Party of Moldovan Communists received 31% of the votes in Gagauzia compared with about half of the votes in the rest of Moldova, excluding the Transdnistrian Republic.²⁸

Like the previous elections, the 2005 parliamentary election showed a low level of support for Moldovan nationalist and pro-Romanian parties in Gagauz Yeri. Only about 1% of voters in this autonomous region backed the People's Christian Democratic Party, the main nationalist party, which received about 10% of the national vote in Moldova, excluding the Transdnistrian Republic.²⁹

Attitudes towards Russia, the Soviet Union and independence

Various surveys conducted since 1990 demonstrated that Crimean Tatars had negative attitudes towards Russia and the Soviet Union, and demonstrated significant support for Crimean Tatar independence. Analysis of a 1996 survey commissioned by the USIA and conducted by SOCIS-Gallup showed that Crimean Tatars were much less pro-Russian than Russians and Ukrainians in Crimea. Much lower proportions of Crimean Tatars (8%) than Russians (59%) and Ukrainians (41%) favoured Crimea becoming a part of Russia. Crimean independence received stronger backing among Crimean Tatars (27%) than among Russians and Ukrainians in the region (15% and 17% respectively). This indicated a considerable level of support for Crimean Tatar independence. Regarding the status of Crimea, more than half of Crimean Tatars (54%), compared with 29% of Ukrainians and 13% of Russians, said that the region should be a part of Ukraine (Table 1). A quarter (26%) of Crimean Tatars, compared with 13% of Ukrainians and 4% of Russians in the region, supported the independence of Ukraine. Some 62% of Crimean Tatars, 80% of Ukrainians and

TABLE 1
PREFERENCES CONCERNING FUTURE OF CRIMEA (%)

	<i>Crimean Tatars</i>	<i>Russians</i>	<i>Ukrainians</i>
Part of Russia	8	59	41
Independent Crimea	27	15	17
Part of Ukraine	54	13	29
Other	11	13	13

Source: 1996 USIA/SOCIS-Gallup Poll.

91% of Russians in Crimea favoured a confederation of Ukraine with Russia and other former Soviet Republics.³⁰ It is noteworthy that not only ethnic Russians but also ethnic Ukrainians in Crimea were much more supportive of the confederation option and less supportive of the independence of Ukraine than the respondents in Ukraine as a whole. The Ukrainian national identity was historically least developed in Crimea, which before its transfer to Soviet Ukraine in 1954 was a part of the Russian Federation in the Soviet Union.

A survey conducted in Crimea revealed significant political cleavages between Crimean Tatars and Slavs, i.e. Russians and Ukrainians, on foreign policy issues. Crimean Tatars favoured establishment of a Crimean Tatar Autonomous Republic and opposed any reunification of Crimea with Russia, while Russians and Ukrainians opposed the idea of a Crimean Tatar autonomous region in Crimea. The Crimean Tatar respondents supported the NATO intervention in Serbia on behalf of Kosovo Albanians. In contrast, Russians and Ukrainians in Crimea had very negative attitudes toward the NATO intervention.³¹

Surveys and referendums revealed that the Gagauz, in contrast to Crimean Tatars, had positive attitudes towards the Soviet Union and Russia. The 1990 survey conducted by the Department of Sociology of the Academy of Sciences of Moldova and the Institute of Social and Political Studies showed that 75% of respondents in the Gagauz region supported the preservation of Moldova's membership of the Soviet Union. Only the Transdnistria region had a comparable level of pro-Soviet orientation (82%). Support for the independence of Moldova showed a reverse pattern. It was lowest in Transdnistria (13%) and Gagauz Yeri (19%) and highest in cities and districts in Bessarabian Moldova (37–41%). The issue of Moldova's unification with Romania received low support (2–6%) in all regions of Moldova.³²

In the March 1991 all-Union referendum on the future of the Soviet Union the overwhelming majority (about 82%) of those who took part in the Gagauz region referendum voted for the preservation of the Soviet Union. The level of support for the preservation of the Soviet Union among the Gagauz was comparable to that among residents of Transdnistria (about 93%).³³

The 1998 Laitin/Hough survey revealed that the Gagauz were more pro-Russian in their orientation than ethnic Russians in Moldova.³⁴ Some 58% of the Gagauz respondents favoured confederative/united government with Russia, and 9% favoured independent government. No Gagauz respondents supported confederation or a union with Romania. In comparison, 43% of Russians and 21% of Moldovans supported a

TABLE 2
PREFERENCES CONCERNING FUTURE OF MOLDOVA (%)

	<i>Gagauz</i>	<i>Russians</i>	<i>Moldovans</i>	<i>Other</i>
Confederation/union with Russia	58	43	21	36
Independent	9	7	31	12
Confederation/union with Romania	0	1	4	7
Other	33	49	44	45
<i>N</i>	126	362	627	422

Source: 1998 Laitin/Hough survey.

confederative or united government with Russia. Some 7% of Russians and 31% of Moldovans supported independence, while 1% and 4% respectively favoured a confederation or a union with Romania (Table 2).

In contrast to Crimean Tatars, who supported the independence of Ukraine from the Soviet Union, Gagauz opposed the independence of Moldova and backed a significant degree of autonomy or outright independence of their region, in part to preserve their ties to Russia. Several districts in the south of Moldova, which were populated by Gagauz, declared the creation of a Gagauz Soviet Socialist Republic in August 1990. In the December 1991 referendum in the Gagauz region about 95% of the voters voted in favour of the independence of Gagauzia. The participation rate was 85%.³⁵ The region boycotted the 1991 presidential election in Moldova. In an election separately held in the Gagauz region, Stefan Topal, leader of a Gagauz secessionist movement, won over 90% of the vote and became president of the unrecognised Gagauz Republic in 1991. The central government of Moldova initially opposed the creation of the Gagauz Republic and declared martial law in the region.

It is noteworthy that the Gagauz separatists received support in their conflict with the Moldovan nationalists and central government of Moldova from the authorities of the unrecognised Transdnistrian Republic, Moldova's secessionist region which strongly favoured a pro-Russian orientation. The Gagauz authorities maintained links with the Transdnistrian government in spite of its conflict with Chisinau. Gagauz and Transdnistrian separatist leaders, including Stefan Topal and Igor Smirnov, were arrested by the central authorities in Moldova for expressing support of the coup attempt organised by hard-line Soviet leaders in the Soviet Union in August 1991.³⁶

An agreement on autonomy of the Gagauz region was approved by the Moldovan parliament in 1994. The Gagauz autonomous region, also called Gagauz Yeri or Gagauzia, consists of the districts and villages which voted for inclusion in the region in referendums.³⁷ Ethnic Gagauz account for 79% of the population of the autonomous region, while ethnic Moldovans constitute about 4% and ethnic Russians about 5% of the population.³⁸ The Gagauz autonomous region negotiated for the right to decide its own status in the event that Moldova reunited with Romania.³⁹ Even after they received considerable autonomy in Moldova, Gagauz leaders wanted to elevate the region's constitutional status.

Surveys indicate that Soviet identity was weaker among Crimean Tatars than among Gagauz. For example, a survey conducted in Crimea in 2000 found that Soviet identity was important to only 4% of Crimean Tatars, compared with 18% of

Russians. Soviet identity was completely absent among 60% of Crimean Tatars, compared with 30% of Russians. Conversely, ethnic identity was important to 80% of Crimean Tatars and 26% of Russians in Crimea.⁴⁰

A survey conducted in the Odessa region in 1995 found that 35% of Gagauz considered themselves citizens of the Soviet Union, while 22% considered themselves representatives of the Gagauz people, and only 12% considered themselves citizens of independent Ukraine. Some 17% of Gagauz replied that it did not matter for them, and 14% were not sure.⁴¹

Similarly, Gagauz and Crimean Tatars differed in their attitudes towards Soviet history. The 1995 World Values Survey showed that Gagauz were much more favourable in their evaluation of the Soviet system than respondents from other regions of Moldova, excluding Transdnistria, which was not covered by the survey. As many as 80% of the respondents from Gagauz Yeri gave communist political systems a positive rating, compared with 41% in other Bessarabian regions of Moldova. A negative rating of the Soviet system was given by 18% of the respondents in the Gagauz region, 21% in Chisinau city and 30% in the rest of the Bessarabian part of Moldova.⁴² The 1998 Laitin/Hough survey showed that 72% of ethnic Gagauz expressed regret about the break-up of the Soviet Union, while only 19% viewed the collapse of the USSR in a positive light. In comparison, 74% of the respondents in the unrecognised pro-Russian Transdnistrian Republic considered the fall of the Soviet Union harmful; 15% of Transdnistrians regarded the collapse of the Soviet Union as good.

The 1995 World Values Survey showed that the dislike of Stalinists in Bessarabian Moldova was lowest among respondents from the Gagauz region; 0% of Gagauz and 12% of Moldovans expressed dislike of Stalinists. In contrast, 44% of Gagauz and 9% of Moldovans from the Bessarabian region of the country selected Neo-Nazis as the least liked group.

Crimean Tatars expressed a negative attitude towards Stalin and his supporters. This attitude was demonstrated in their mass rallies marking anniversaries of Stalin's deportation of Crimean Tatars and in their opposition to a monument to Stalin in Crimea. For example, tens of thousands, or about 10–15% of the whole adult population of Crimean Tatars in Ukraine, participated in a rally in 2004 commemorating the 60th anniversary of the deportation.⁴³ Leaders of the Medzhlis opposed plans, which were supported by Crimean communists, to erect a monument to Stalin, Roosevelt and Churchill in commemoration of the 60th anniversary of the Yalta conference in Crimea during World War II.⁴⁴

Attitudes towards other ethnic groups

Survey data show that Crimean Tatars have overwhelmingly a negative perception of Russians and Ukrainians. The Tatar respondents regard themselves and Slavs as completely different groups that have a limited degree of interaction. One-third of Russians and Ukrainians also viewed Crimean Tatars negatively. In 30% of cases Russians and Ukrainians expressed positive perceptions of Crimean Tatars.⁴⁵

Respondents to the 2001 nationwide survey conducted in Ukraine by the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology regarded Crimean Tatars as the second most

distant group in Ukraine after Gypsies. Crimean Tatars had a score of 5.11 on the Bogardus index of social distance, compared with 2.43 for Russians, 3.30 for Belorussians, 4.45 for Poles, 4.54 for Jews, 4.62 for Moldovans and 5.75 for Gypsies. This index ranges from 1, when all respondents agree to have representatives of a given group as their family members, to 7, when all respondents would not permit group members to enter the country. The score of 2 means that members of a group are accepted as close friends; 3 means they are accepted as neighbours; 4 means they are accepted as co-workers; 5 means they are accepted as residents of Ukraine and 6 means they are accepted as visitors to Ukraine.⁴⁶

In contrast, Gagauz have a positive attitude towards Russians and Ukrainians. The 1995 survey of Gagauz living in the Odessa region of Ukraine revealed that they were much more likely to approve of inter-marriage with Slavs than with members of Turkic ethnic groups. Some 67% were willing to accept marriage of their close relatives to Russians, 61% to Bulgarians and 60% to Ukrainians, compared with 43% to Turks and 28% to Azeris.⁴⁷

Gagauz in Moldova expressed extremely favourable attitudes towards the Russian language even though their own language has much more in common with other Turkic languages, such as Turkish, Azeri and Turkmen, than with Russian. The 1998 Laitin/Hough survey showed that 97% of Gagauz favoured Russian as a mandatory subject, while a mere 3% were against such a measure. The Gagauz preference for the Russian language was comparable to support expressed by other ethnic minorities, i.e. mostly Russians and Ukrainians, in Moldova (91% in favour and 6% against). In comparison, 69% of ethnic Moldovans in Bessarabia and 98% in Transdnistria supported the Russian language being a required subject in all schools, while 26% and 1% respectively opposed this idea.

Historical experience and evolution of the political cultures of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz

Differences in historical experience between Crimean Tatars and Gagauz were linked to religion. In medieval times Crimean Tatars adopted Islam, while Gagauz became Orthodox Christians. The adoption of these religions was a critical juncture in the emergence of the political culture of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz. Since the Middle Ages, Muslim and Orthodox religions deeply influenced the values of the absolute majority of the population, especially in the Ottoman Empire, and the religious identity of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz was more developed than their national and class identities.

The main line of division in the Ottoman Empire, including the Crimean khanate, which became a vassal state of the Ottoman Empire at the end of the fifteenth century, ran between Muslims and Christians. Muslims were the most privileged group in the Ottoman Empire. The government treated non-Muslims as members of lower social groups. Thus Christians, compared with Muslims, had to pay higher taxes, wear different clothing and face religious and legal discrimination; they could not carry arms and a significant number of them were made slaves or massacred during wars and uprisings. While the religious law of Islam recognised Orthodox Christians as 'People of the Book' and granted them a protected but second-class status, informal

institutions and practices in the Ottoman Empire did not always follow this formal interpretation of the law, as evidenced by the enslaving of Orthodox Christian children in the Balkans for military and government service, the genocide of Christian Armenians during World War I and the persecution of the Orthodox Gagauz and Bulgarians.⁴⁸

According to available estimates, the scale of Ottoman slavery was comparable to that on the other side of the Atlantic.⁴⁹ Ukraine, Southern Russia and the Caucasus were the major sources of slaves. It is estimated that in Ukraine alone about 2–2.5 million people were forced into slavery or killed during frequent raids carried out by Crimean Tatars over several centuries.⁵⁰ Agricultural slavery in the Ottoman Empire was not as widespread as in the US, but it existed along with military, household and maritime forms of slavery. While Ottoman slavery differed in its forms from American slavery, the experience of the small minority of slaves who, like a Ukrainian wife of Sultan Suleiman the Magnificent, rose to the top of the Ottoman ranks was not representative of the experience of most slaves from Russia and Ukraine.

Slavery and slave trading were important institutions in the Crimean khanate.⁵¹ Because Islam prohibited the enslavement of fellow Muslims, Orthodox Ukrainians and Russians were targets of frequent raids by Crimean Tatars. A significant number of them, estimated at tens of thousands each year, were captured and sold as slaves in Crimea. This practice lasted several centuries.⁵²

This historical experience played a major role in the formation and cultural transmission among Ukrainians and Russians of a popular image that associated Crimean Tatars with slavery. The role of Ukrainian and Russian Cossacks as defenders against slave and military raids conducted by Crimean Tatars became entrenched and mythologised in popular memory, even though the Crimean khans and Ukrainian Cossack leaders were allies in a number of battles. The very name Ukraine took hold during this period. It meant 'the borderland' or 'on the edge'. The Polish Kingdom, which controlled large parts of Ukraine, and the Russian Empire tried to use Ukrainian peasants, many of whom settled in areas close to the Ottoman Empire to escape from serfdom, as guards against incursions by the Crimean Tatars. It is noteworthy that these frontier warriors became known as Cossacks, a term derived from a Turkic word for 'adventurer' or 'free man'.⁵³

The Russian conquest of Crimea at the end of the eighteenth century brought a major change in the historical experience of Crimean Tatars; they became subject to discrimination as Muslims and potential allies of the Ottoman Empire in its frequent wars with the Russian Empire. As a result, a large proportion of the Crimean Tatar population migrated to the Ottoman Empire.⁵⁴

The historical experience of Gagauz in the Ottoman Empire and the Russian Empire was the opposite of the experience of Crimean Tatars. Before their arrival in southern Moldova and the neighbouring area in the Odessa region of Ukraine at the end of the eighteenth century and beginning of the nineteenth century, the Gagauz populated the Dobrudja region, which is now a part of Romania and Bulgaria.⁵⁵ The reason for the mass resettlement of the Gagauz was their adherence to Orthodox Christianity in the Ottoman Empire at the time of the Russo–Turkish wars. The Russian tsars proclaimed themselves defenders of the Orthodox people in the Balkans. They were involved, including militarily, in Balkan politics and provided lands for the

Gagauz in Bessarabia. The forced migration of the Gagauz was a critical juncture in the formation of their pro-Russian political culture because this event had a significant effect on the lives of the absolute majority of Gagauz.⁵⁶

World War II and the mass expulsion of Crimean Tatars by Stalin, which affected the life of almost every Crimean Tatar, reinforced their cultural differentiation from Russians and Ukrainians. During the war, about 10% of the Crimean Tatars, a large part of them voluntarily, joined the German military and police units and fought against Soviet partisans. Although comparable proportions of Crimean Tatars served in the Soviet Army and belonged to Soviet partisans in Crimea, the proportion of Tatars collaborating with the Nazis was much higher than the proportions of collaborators among Russians and Ukrainians.⁵⁷

Available data indicate that about 13–15% of Russians and Ukrainians in Crimea perished as a result of the Nazi genocidal policy, which included mass executions, deprivation of elementary medical care and deliberate starvation of civilians and POWs. Approximately 5–7% of Russians and Ukrainians in Crimea who served in the Soviet Army were killed fighting Nazi Germany and its allies. About 8–10% of Russians and Ukrainians in Crimea were sent by the Nazi wartime administration to forced labour.⁵⁸ The Nazis, who regarded not only Russians and Ukrainians but also Crimean Tatars as racially inferior, planned to colonise Crimea and exterminate or expel most of the local population to Siberia.⁵⁹

At the end of the war Stalin collectively punished the Crimean Tatars because a fraction of them had collaborated with the Nazis. All Crimean Tatars were deported along with other ethnic minorities by force from Crimea to Central Asia in 1944, and the autonomous status of the Crimean Tatar Republic was eliminated. A significant proportion of Crimean Tatars, estimated at more than 20%, perished during the deportation and in its aftermath as a result of lack of food and medical care.⁶⁰ Like the experience of Russians and Ukrainians during the war in Crimea, the experience of Crimean Tatars during their mass deportation and life in exile had a profound effect on the evolution of their political culture.

Both the ethnic cleansing of Crimean Tatars and the historical experience of Russians and Ukrainians during World War II and subsequent mythologisation of these events on both sides fueled political tensions between Crimean Tatars and Russians, as well as pro-Russian Ukrainians. The deportation and exile experience, which lasted until the end of the Soviet Union, led to the emergence of a Crimean Tatar national movement. This movement, which initially focused on the demand of return to Crimea, received strong support among Crimean Tatars by the time the Soviet Union collapsed.⁶¹ Similarly, pro-communist and pro-Russian parties and politicians in Crimea often invoked the historical experience during World War II to justify their political demands, in particular, in their stance towards Crimean Tatars.

The experience of Gagauz during Romanian rule in Moldova in 1918–40 and during World War II was more negative than the experience of Moldovans. After Bessarabian Moldova became a part of Romania, Gagauz suffered discrimination, because the Romanian government favoured Moldovans, whom it considered to be Romanians. The Romanian government was an ally of Nazi Germany, and it had a large degree of autonomy in its policy in Moldova, including the Gagauz region, during World War II. The wartime policy of the Romanian government discriminated

against and repressed the Gagauz, Russian and Ukrainian minorities. The Gagauz cited this experience as a reason for their opposition to Moldovan independence and possible unification of Moldova with Romania at the beginning of the 1990s.⁶²

The Gagauz were one of the least educated and impoverished groups in Moldova during Romanian rule in 1918–40 and 1941–44. After Moldova came under Soviet rule as a result of World War II, a significant number of Gagauz benefited from the Soviet policy of mass education and economic development in the region. This experience helped to foster pro-communist and pro-Russian political values among Gagauz.

Many Gagauz died during a post-war famine when Bessarabian Moldova again came under Soviet rule. However, like the artificial famine in Eastern Ukraine in the 1930s, the famine in Moldova did not transform the political culture of Gagauz into an anti-Russian and anti-Soviet one. Because of the totalitarian nature of the Soviet state, which controlled all institutions with the exception of the family, maintained strict censorship and spread propaganda that prevented dissemination of information about this event, many Gagauz were unaware of the extent of the famine beyond their own personal experience or experience of their families. In contrast to many Crimean Tatars in exile in Central Asia, who attributed the extremely high death rate from infectious diseases and lack of food to Soviet policy towards them, the Gagauz attributed the famine to natural causes and to the destruction of agriculture and industry that was brought by World War II, and they did not associate the famine with Soviet policy towards them.

Prior political culture, which set different patterns of worldview among Crimean Tatars and Gagauz, explains the different effects of these historical experiences on the evolution of their political values. This interpretation is supported by a comparison of the historical experience of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz with the historical experience of Bulgarians. Like the Gagauz, many Bulgarians resettled from the Ottoman Empire to Bessarabian and Crimean regions of the Russian Empire because of their persecution as Orthodox Christians. This critical juncture fostered pro-Russian political culture among Bulgarians in the Russian Empire. Therefore, the deportation of the whole population of Bulgarians (more than 12,000) along with Crimean Tatars from Crimea to other regions of the Soviet Union because of charges of collaboration with the Nazi occupation authorities during World War II did not transform the political culture of Bulgarians into an anti-Russian or anti-Soviet one either.

There is a lack of detailed studies of precise mechanisms that transmitted the historical experience of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz from one generation to another. As noted, this problem especially concerns the Gagauz. However, available data make it possible to outline a general mechanism of such transmission.

Socialisation in the family and religion played crucial roles in the cultural transmission of the historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz. Family was a key institution that was not directly controlled by the Soviet state and the Communist Party. Each consecutive generation was brought up on personal, folk and historical stories told by their parents and grandparents. As a result, the contemporary population of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz retained their distinct historical memory, or a modern interpretation of past historical experiences that were to a certain extent simplified, distorted and mythologised in the process of inter-generational transmission.

Muslim and Orthodox organised religions helped to transfer the distinct political culture of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz from one generation to another in the Ottoman Empire, the Russian Empire and to some extent in the Soviet Union. The role of family and religion was especially important in this respect in the Ottoman Empire and the Russian Empire because the absolute majority of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz were illiterate. For example, according to the 1897 census data, only 7% of Gagauz were literate.⁶³ Even though religion was persecuted in the Soviet Union, the absolute majority of Gagauz and Crimean Tatars preserved their religious beliefs. For example, the 1995 World Values Survey showed that 98% of the respondents from Gagauzia identified themselves as Orthodox Christians.

The education system in the Soviet Union promoted convergence of political cultures of different ethnic groups. However, in the case of Crimean Tatars this mechanism of socialisation reinforced their differences from Russians, Ukrainians and Gagauz. Soviet historical textbooks and literary texts emphasised military conflicts between Crimean Tatars and Ukrainian and Russian Cossacks, slave raids by Crimean Tatars and military help provided by the Russian government to the Gagauz, Bulgarian and other Orthodox Christian people of the Ottoman Empire. The history of World War II in Soviet textbooks presented Crimean Tatars as Nazi collaborators and ignored the ethnic cleansing of Crimean Tatars by the Soviet government. Soviet mass media and popular culture promoted similar historical images of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz.⁶⁴

Conclusion

This article has examined differing political orientations of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz. Crimean Tatars in Ukraine consistently expressed anti-communist and anti-Russian political preferences, while Gagauz in Moldova and the Odessa region of Ukraine showed strong support for pro-communist and pro-Russian parties and politicians and a union with Russia.

Analysis of a variety of data from surveys, elections and referendums demonstrates that the different political orientations of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in post-communist Ukraine and Moldova reflect different political cultures. Comparative historical analysis indicates that distinct historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in the Ottoman Empire, the Russian Empire, Romania and the Soviet Union led to the emergence and evolution of the divergent political cultures of these ethnic groups. Adherence to Islam, the institution of slavery in the Ottoman Empire, experience of ethnic cleansing and long-term exile in the Soviet Union were crucial factors in the formation of the anti-Russian and anti-communist political values of Crimean Tatars. In contrast, the persecution of Gagauz because of their adherence to Orthodox Christianity in the Ottoman Empire, their mass migration to the Russian Empire, and experience during Romanian and Soviet rule fostered pro-Russian and pro-communist values among Gagauz.

The distinct historical experiences of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz were transferred to the post-communist period with the help of socialisation in the family, organised religion and mass education. However, further studies of precise mechanisms of the

emergence and transmission of the political cultures of these ethnic minorities are needed because previous research on this issue is very limited.

This study, which shows a significant role of cultural legacies in shaping political behaviour and attitudes among Crimean Tatars and Gagauz in Ukraine and Moldova, has implications for researching ethnic and regional conflicts and cleavages in other countries. Because other ethnic groups have political divisions and historical legacies that are similar to the differences in political orientation and historical experience of Crimean Tatars and Gagauz, the comparative analysis of these two Turkic-speaking peoples is helpful in understanding the influence of cultural factors on ethnic conflicts and cleavages in other countries.

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